

Case Study: UPI / Online Payment Fraud

UPI and online payment fraud is a common cybercrime where attackers trick users into transferring money or sharing sensitive payment details. This fraud usually begins when a victim receives a phone call, SMS, or WhatsApp message pretending to be from a bank, delivery service, customer support, or even a college authority. The message often creates urgency, such as a failed payment, blocked account, or refund request.

The fraud typically happens step by step. First, the attacker gains the victim's trust by using official-looking language or fake logos. Next, the victim is asked to approve a UPI request, scan a QR code, or share a one-time password (OTP). Many victims mistakenly believe QR codes are used to receive money, but scanning them can authorize a payment instead. Once the victim approves the request, money is instantly transferred to the attacker's account.

College students are common targets because they frequently use UPI apps, online shopping, and digital wallets. Students may also lack awareness of safe payment practices or panic when faced with urgent messages.

The consequences include financial loss, stress, and difficulty recovering stolen money. In some cases, victims may also face misuse of their personal data. Such frauds highlight the importance of digital awareness, cautious online behavior, and understanding how UPI transactions actually work.